

Few Indian athletes will be heading to the Asian Games with a heavier weight of expectations than young Esha Singh, who is being considered one of India's sure-shot medal contenders. One look at her world rankings—No. 1 in 25m rapid fire and No. 2 in 10m pistol—coupled with her stellar form in 2025-26, winning multiple World Cup golds, and one understands why. "What I am planning and training for, I have been able to execute exactly that in competitions," says Esha. Like 2024 Olympics double bronze medallist Manu Bhaker, Esha, too, has forged her path in two disciplines and made the Asian Games squad for both.

Among the gamut of shooting talent India has at its disposal, Esha stands apart with her easy-going attitude—not displaying the steely-eyed mien associated with the sport, yet excelling on the range. "I don't have a head-down approach. Instead, I have a good switch on and off mode and get into the zone required easily," she says. When not on the range, she likes to dabble in gourmet cooking, sketching, reading and enjoys the company of friends and family. Singh's affinity for shooting began because she thought it was easy. "I was quite stupid to think that you don't have to do anything but just stand and shoot," says the Hyderabad girl with a laugh.

Adversity, not success, has taught Esha her biggest lessons. Her maiden Olympics in Paris supplied some hard perspective. "It wasn't a really bad or average performance, but still coming back with what you couldn't have breaks you as a person," she says. "I have become more mature in my sport."

With shooting counted as the sport expected to contribute most to India's medal tally at the Games, Esha is pleased that recognition for the sport has increased. "I have been told, 'you guys make it look like it is easy', but we are working hard to make it seem so," she says. At the Asian Games, vying with Chinese and South Korean shooters, Esha Singh and Team India will be hoping to keep the medals flowing. ■

—Suhani Singh